

How US-Americans define their political views

Research proposal based on the *American Voices Project*

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We plan to study the political views expressed in interviews of a large, quasi-representative sample of US-Americans. Our main research questions are: *What do people care about (politically)? How does this relate to their living condition?* We will use mixed methods: in particular, we will exploit the large size of the sample to quantitatively analyze the qualitative material. Our research will be based on four steps:

1. Analyze questions “How would you describe your political views”?

We will conduct a thematic analysis of questions 27-29 and 199,¹ on political attitudes. Our primary methodology will be manual coding: we will read and code one-by-one the answers. Of particular interest will be the issues mentioned, the level of interest, and the political leaning. On top of the manual coding, we will also run keyword searches and use generative AI to classify the answers. We will measure the accuracy of automatic coding with respect to manual coding. Based on our interpretation of the transcripts, we will also produce a narrative analysis by identifying overarching patterns in the respondents’ narratives, paying attention to specific themes: purchasing power, the environment, inequality, and immigration. Finally, we will compare the frequencies of topics to those that appeared in open-ended questions of a representative survey of US-Americans which asked questions such as “What are your main concerns these days?” and “What are your needs or wishes?”.

2. Automated coding of the interviews

We will use generative AI to code each question of every interview and fill a database summarizing the responses. From this database, we will estimate synthetic indicators of the standard of living, health level, and social connections of the respondents.

3. Socioeconomic determinants of political views

Based on the database constructed in the previous step, we will study the determinants of political views. In particular, we will analyze what correlates with the concern for one’s purchasing power, and test whether it correlates with variables such as income, indebtedness, or age. We will use linear regressions, variance decomposition, and regression trees.

4. (Optional) Emotional correlates of living conditions: a speech recognition analysis

If we are granted access to the audio files, we will use speech recognition models to infer the tone and emotion conveyed by each response (e.g. joy, anxiety, apathy...). We will then analyze the socioeconomic determinants of emotions.

¹ These questions ask variants of: *Do you vote? What are your political views? How have they changed recently? What would you say to a policymaker?*